

DARK SQUARES

Season One – Episode One

"THE WOODS"

Written by Alfred HJR

© Alfred HJR / Alien51Smoke LLC. All Rights Reserved.

Confidential – For Professional Review Only. Do Not Distribute.

© Alfred HJR / Alien51Smoke LLC. All Rights Reserved.
Confidential – For Professional Review Only. Do Not Distribute.

COLD OPEN / TEASER

FADE IN:

EXT. THE WOODS – NEIGHBORHOOD STREET – EARLY EVENING

The neighborhood settles into the hour before
streetlights. Not quiet. Not loud.

The specific frequency of a block that is always paying
attention.

A four-family building. Low and wide. The kind of building
that has been here

longer than any of its current residents.

A DOG – small, tan, watchful – sits on the front step.

This is **KIZZY**. She is

facing the street.

A BOY, fourteen, comes around the corner. This is **MANNY**.

He is not rushing.

He is reading. His eyes move over the block the way
someone reads a room they have

been in a hundred times: not looking for anything new, but
confirming that nothing

old has changed.

He checks the building's front door.

He checks the driveway.

He checks the corner where the older boys sometimes stand.

Corner is clear.

He relaxes – slightly, not completely. Relaxing completely
is not something you do

in the Woods.

Kizzy gets up and moves to him.

MANNY (V.O.)

The Woods taught me something school never did. It taught me how to read a face
before the face decided what it was going to be. Taught me how to cross the street
before a situation became a situation. Taught me that a small thing – a wrong look,
a borrowed dollar, a girl someone decided was spoken for – could follow you to your
front door if you weren't paying attention.

(beat)

Most people call it a neighborhood. We called it the test. The test never stopped.

Manny reaches the front step. He sits next to Kizzy. She leans against him. He
watches the street.

From inside the building – from the apartment low in the building, near the basement
hallway – the sound of a television.

CUT TO TITLE: DARK SQUARES

ACT ONE

INT. ELLA MAE'S APARTMENT – CONTINUOUS

Small. Specific. Everything in it earned.

ELLA MAE, late thirties, moves through the kitchen with the efficiency of a

person who has a shift to get to and a house to hold together before she leaves.

KEITH, ten years old, sits at the kitchen table with his homework in front of

him and his eyes on something else entirely.

ELLA MAE

Keith. That homework.

KEITH

I'm doing it.

ELLA MAE

You're looking at the wall.

KEITH

I do both.

Ella Mae gives him a look. The look does not require words. Keith looks at the homework.

ELLA MAE

Manny's home?

KEITH

He's on the steps.

She nods. She moves to the window. She can see the front step from here – just barely, at an angle. Manny and Kizzy, watching the street. Something in her face: relief she will not say out loud.

INT. ELLA MAE'S APARTMENT – DOORWAY – MOMENTS LATER

Ella Mae stands in the doorway in her work uniform. Work bag at her shoulder. She looks at Manny and Keith until they are both listening.

ELLA MAE

The house rule.

This is not a question.

MANNY

The house rule. Yes.

ELLA MAE

What is it?

MANNY

Whatever's out there stays out there.

ELLA MAE

Whatever's out there stays out there. And?

MANNY

And if you bring it in, it's on you.

She holds his look for a moment.

ELLA MAE

Don't be out late. Streetlights come on, you're in.

MANNY

I know.

ELLA MAE

I know you know. Say it anyway.

MANNY

Streetlights come on, we're in.

She pulls the door behind her. The lock clicks.

MANNY (V.O.)

She did not say it like a suggestion. She said it like scripture.

Manny sits with Kizzy. The street settles into the hour.

MANNY (V.O.)

Whatever happened outside stayed outside. Whatever pride, disrespect,

misunderstanding, or trouble followed a person home had to die before it reached

her living room.

Keith appears at the doorway, watching his brother.

EXT. THE WOODS – LATER

Manny and Keith ride bikes through the block. Two boys in motion, reading the

neighborhood the same way their mother reads them: watching for what changed,

confirming what is still the same.

Kizzy races behind them.

They pass a stickball game. A basketball bouncing on cracked pavement. Older boys

carrying a boom box.

MANNY (V.O.)

Manny understood that rule better than anyone. He was the oldest. Keith was his little brother. Four years separated them, but in the Woods, four years could feel like a whole lifetime. Keith swerves close to Manny, grinning. Manny reaches out and steadies him before he can clip the curb.

MANNY (V.O.)

Manny was not Keith's father. But he carried pieces of that job anyway. Manny watches Keith stand on the pedals, arms out like wings.

MANNY (V.O.)

Keith followed crowds easily. People liked him. He could make anybody laugh, and that gift made him welcome in places Manny did not always want him to be.

EXT. EMPTY LOT / ALLEY – LATE AFTERNOON

Keith hears the boom box from the corner and starts moving to the beat. He tries to make Manny laugh with a ridiculous dance. Manny does, despite himself.

MANNY (V.O.)

Music was already there, even then. Coming from car windows. From radios on porches. From older boys carrying boom boxes. Hip-hop was not background noise to them. It was weather. It was the sound of growing up. Manny and Keith pause at the mouth of the alley, listening. Older kids call Keith over. Keith heads toward them without thinking. Manny catches the back of his shirt.

MANNY

Not over there.

KEITH

I'm just talking.

MANNY

Talk from here.

Keith rolls his eyes, but stays. Kizzy plants herself beside Manny's leg.

The older boys lose interest and move on.

MANNY (V.O.)

Some boys attract friends. Some attract trouble. Keith had a way of attracting both.

ACT TWO

EXT. THE WOODS – NIGHT

The streetlights are on. The boys should be home. Instead they have found a

comfortable pocket at the edge of the block where the rules feel slightly further away.

MANNY (V.O.)

When Ella Mae worked late, the boys had more freedom than they should have had.

The neighborhood opened up after the streetlights came on.

A boom box somewhere down the block. The older boys again, moving slow.

Keith watches them. Something in his body wants to follow.

KEITH

You know Steve?

MANNY

Which Steve.

KEITH

The one with all the records. He's got turntables in his room. James said he lets people come listen.

Manny files this away. Does not respond immediately.

KEITH

You ever see him work?

MANNY

No.

KEITH

James said it sounds like a whole radio station.

Manny looks toward the older boys. Then back at his brother.

MANNY

You doing your homework?

KEITH

Why you always change the subject?

MANNY

Because when I ask about homework and you don't answer, that tells me something.

Keith makes a face. Kicks a stone down the alley. Kizzy chases it.

KEITH

Homework's done.

MANNY

Then we can go in.

EXT. THE WOODS – CONTINUOUS

The brothers ride side by side beneath the streetlights. Their building waits ahead.

MANNY (V.O.)

In those days, the Woods felt bigger than the whole world. They had no idea they

would one day move away from it.

Keith laughs at something only he understands. Manny watches him, protective and quiet.

MANNY (V.O.)

They had no idea the Woods would follow them anyway. Kizzy runs between the bikes as the boys reach the front of the building. They stop. Manny looks at the corner one more time. Still clear.

KEITH

You ever scared?
The question comes from nowhere. Manny looks at him.

MANNY

Of what.

KEITH

I don't know. Everything.
Manny considers this. Does not rush the answer.

MANNY

Yeah. Sometimes.

KEITH

What do you do?

MANNY

Keep moving. Read the room. Make sure you're with me.
Keith absorbs this.

KEITH

That's it?

MANNY

That's a lot.
Keith nods, satisfied. Kizzy noses at the building's front door.

ACT THREE

EXT. THE WOODS – THE FOLLOWING DAYS

A MONTAGE of the brothers' ordinary life in the Woods:

– Manny helps Keith with math at the kitchen table. Keith draws pictures in the

margins when he thinks Manny isn't looking. Manny sees. Says nothing.

– The brothers play stickball in the alley with neighborhood kids. Manny lets Keith win a close call. Keith does not notice.

– Manny walks the long way around the corner with the older boys when he and Keith are coming home. Keith clocks the route without asking why.

– Kizzy curls at the foot of the brothers' shared room. The building is quiet.

Outside, the block is not.

– Early morning. Ella Mae leaves for the early shift. She stops at the boys'

doorway. Watches them sleep. Pulls the door closed.

MANNY (V.O.)

The Woods was not just a neighborhood. It was a classroom, a warning, a playground,

and a test. It taught boys how to run, how to hide, how to laugh when nothing was

funny, and how to read a face before a word came out of a mouth.

EXT. CORNER NEAR JUNKYARD – DAY

Manny and Keith stand at the edge of the junkyard, looking in.

To anyone walking past: two boys at a fence. But to Manny and Keith, this is

somewhere they have named in their heads, somewhere that belongs to them.

KEITH

This is our kingdom.

He says it with complete conviction. The specific seriousness of a ten-year-old who means it.

MANNY

Yeah.

KEITH

Future emperors of the junkyard.

MANNY

You read that in a book or you made that up?

KEITH

Both.

Manny laughs. Kizzy barks at a pigeon that wanders too close.

MANNY (V.O.)

That was Keith. He could build an empire in his head so fast it felt real by the time he finished the sentence.

INT. ELLA MAE'S APARTMENT – EVENING

Ella Mae at the table with bills and a cup of coffee going cold. Manny sits nearby,

doing homework. Keith is already asleep.

The apartment is small enough that you can hear the building breathe – footsteps

above, a TV through the wall, the elevator catching somewhere in the shaft.

Ella Mae looks up from the bills. Looks at Manny.

ELLA MAE

You keeping your brother close?

MANNY

Yes, ma'am.

ELLA MAE

Not too close. He needs room.

MANNY

I know.

ELLA MAE

But close enough.

MANNY

I know.

She nods. Looks back at the bills. Then back at him.

ELLA MAE

You hear about the Reyes boy?

Manny does not respond immediately. He has heard.

MANNY

I heard.

ELLA MAE

Then you know why the rule exists.

She picks up the coffee. It's cold. She does not put it back down.

ELLA MAE

This house is the one thing the street doesn't get. You understand me?

MANNY

Yes, ma'am.

ELLA MAE

Good. Go to sleep.

Manny closes his book. But he does not go to sleep yet. He sits with it.

ACT FOUR

EXT. THE WOODS – GRAVEYARD NIGHT – WEEKS LATER

Night. The graveyard at the edge of the neighborhood. Trees and iron fence and the

specific dark of a place that is never fully lit.

Manny and Keith stand at the gate. Keith insisted. Manny came because Keith came.

This is the dare. The thing you do to prove you are not afraid of what is already behind you.

KEITH

You go first.

MANNY

No.

KEITH

You're older.

MANNY

That means I know better.

KEITH

(already moving)

I'll go first.

He pushes open the iron gate. Manny catches it before it closes behind him.

They walk in together.

The graveyard is just a graveyard. Headstones, grass worn thin, a chain-link section

where newer stones wait. Quiet.

Keith stands in the middle of it and holds his arms out.

KEITH

I'm not scared.

MANNY

Okay.

KEITH

I'm really not scared.

MANNY

I believe you.

KEITH

Are *you* scared?

Manny looks around. The dark. The stones. The gate still slightly open behind them.

MANNY

Yeah.

KEITH

(surprised)

Yeah?

MANNY

A little.

Keith thinks about this. Then decides it is the most honest and correct answer he has ever received.

KEITH

Cool.

They stand in the graveyard for another moment. Just standing in it. Proving to themselves and each other that they can. Kizzy waits at the gate. She will not come in.

EXT. THE WOODS — CONTINUOUS — WALKING HOME

The brothers walk home through the empty streets. Late enough that the block is quiet. Early enough that no one is asking questions.

MANNY (V.O.)

The graveyard bet was their thing. It always would be. Years later, when the world had gotten complicated in ways they could not have imagined from that night, they would still know: they had stood in the dark together. They had not run. Keith walks close. Close enough that their shoulders occasionally touch.

MANNY (V.O.)

Before the Rocks, before Lucky's studio, before Sarah, before the party that would

carry a name nobody wanted to say out loud – there was the Woods.

Kizzy moves at their heels.

MANNY (V.O.)

And the Woods, in its own way, loved them back.

TAG

EXT. THE WOODS – NIGHT

The brothers ride bikes side by side beneath the streetlights one last time.

Their building waits. Kizzy runs between their wheels.

MANNY (V.O.)

This is what childhood sounds like from the inside of it.
Before you know it is

childhood. Before you understand what it costs to leave it behind.

The building's front door opens. The lobby light spills out.

The boys disappear into it.

Kizzy follows.

The door closes.

MANNY (V.O.)

Some tests you pass. Some tests change what passing means.

(long beat)

The Woods was still out there. It always would be.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

DARK SQUARES – Season One, Episode One: "The Woods"

© Alfred HJR / Alien51Smoke LLC. All Rights Reserved.